

The Argent Saga — Chronicle of the Vell and the Korraxin

Part One — The Old Bright

Long before the Eclipse, when the Five Spiral Suns still held the rim worlds in their slow cradle, a child was born on the cliff-shelf of Halen Veyr to a stonecutter named Devyn Solveh. The child was Aenaria, and from her seventh year she could see the threads of starlight that bound everything to the galactic core. Her father, who could see no such threads, took her to the only people who might believe her: the silent contemplatives who kept watch from the upper terraces of the cliff, men and women who had renounced names. They listened to Aenaria for an hour and then asked her to leave them in silence for nine days.

She returned on the ninth day and was admitted as a Listener. She was twelve years old.

By her thirty-second year she had forged the first of the Argent Blades — narrow, single-edged swords whose steel was alloyed with crystalline starshard from the meteor falls in the Drey Reaches. The blades hummed in the presence of starlight, and the contemplatives, watching her draw the first one, recognized that the order they had been guarding without name for two centuries had at last found its founder. Aenaria Solveh named them the Vell, after the old word for "thread," and at her direction the cliff-monastery of Halen Veyr was carved deeper into the rock. Where there had been three hundred contemplatives, by the year 4317 P.E. (Pre-Eclipse) there were nine thousand Vell. By the time of the Sundering, three centuries later, there were thirty thousand.

The Vell are not a religion. They are a discipline. A Listener may rise to Hand, then to Voice, then — once a generation — one is named the Pale Steward, keeper of the order's first blade, the Heron's Tooth. The blade is the one Aenaria forged in her thirty-second year. It has been drawn nine times in eight centuries: at the funeral of every Pale Steward, and once, at the opening of the Concord of Mireth.

Part Two — The Eclipse and the Sundering

In the year 0 — the date all later calendars revolve around — the second sun of the Yann-Karoth system collapsed without warning. There had been no precursor flare, no heat fluctuation, no dimming. The astronomers of Yann-Karoth, who had been the finest stellar observers in the rim for a thousand years, had no warning. The collapse generated a gravitational shock that crushed the planet's mantle in seventeen minutes.

Of the eight billion inhabitants of Yann-Karoth, three hundred thousand survived. They were the ones who happened to be aboard cargo lifters, mining stations in the outer belt, or training cruisers in the second moon's shadow. Among the survivors was a teacher of

unarmed combat named Vorshal-Ka, who would be remembered by his great-great-grandson Vorsh-Ka the Quiet, current First of the Crimson Council.

The survivors discovered a strange thing. Within two generations, every Korraxin child born off-world possessed combat knowledge their ancestors had earned. A grandchild of Vorshal-Ka could replicate, on first attempt, throws and counters her grandfather had spent twenty years learning. The phenomenon was named **bloodremembrance**, and the Korraxin elders concluded — correctly — that the Eclipse had not killed their people; it had merely scattered them, and in the scattering, awakened something. Every blow learned by a Korraxin is now available to every descendant the first time they raise a fist.

Three hundred and twenty-seven years later, the Sundering of Halen Veyr ended the Old Bright. A void-touched fleet, the Iguen swarm, fell on the cliff-monastery in mid-winter. Twenty-eight thousand Vell died in the assault. Pale Steward Halan Voryn drew the Heron's Tooth in defense of the inner sanctum and held the western gate alone for forty-one minutes; his name is the only one carved into the inner wall of every Vell training hall. Two thousand Vell escaped into the shielded archives below the cliff. They are the ancestors of every Vell alive today.

Part Three — The Concord of Mireth

In the year 412 A.E. (After Eclipse) the Iguen returned. The swarm fell on the colony world of Mireth Hollow, where four thousand civilians had taken refuge in a hollowed-out asteroid orbiting the world's only moon. The defending force was small: forty Vell sword-monks under Voice Tellán Voryn (no relation to Halan, despite the shared name — the Voryn line takes new names every six generations), and ninety-six Korraxin warriors led by First Brevan-Ka of the Ninth Council. They had never fought together. They had never even spoken before the swarm appeared.

The Defense of Mireth Hollow lasted nine days. On the third day, two Vell — Listener Iren Hask and Hand Olen Davros — led a counter-strike on the swarm's mother-shoal. They returned with three hundred fewer Iguen and a captured navigation core that revealed the swarm's path of advance. On the seventh day, Brevan-Ka entered **thrall-burn** for the first recorded time outside ritual, sustaining it for fifty-three seconds — three short of the racial limit — and broke the swarm's eastern flank. He survived, but slept for sixteen days afterward.

On the ninth day the swarm withdrew. Fourteen Vell remained. Forty Korraxin remained. The civilians were intact.

There was no treaty. Tellán Voryn and Brevan-Ka spoke for two hours in the cooling hollow and then drew their blades in the same motion, crossing them above their heads — the Vell

sign for an oath spoken without witnesses, recognized as binding by both orders ever since. The sworn alliance was named the Concord of Mireth, and to this day there is no Concord document, only the line carved on the floor of the hollow where the two leaders stood: *they were enough*.

Part Four — The Korraxin Today

The Crimson Council of Eight rules the Korraxin. There is no king. Each Councilor is ranked by personal duels won; rank is fluid and contested. The current First, Vorsh-Ka the Quiet, has won eighty-one personal duels and refused thirty-four challenges. Refusal is rare — most Councilors accept every challenge to preserve rank — and is considered a sign of restraint, not weakness. Vorsh-Ka's refusals, when surveyed, share a pattern: he refuses challenges where a loss would deprive the Korraxin of leadership during a crisis. The Council respects this without saying so.

Korraxin children are tested at age seven by the **Walk Across the Coals** — a ritual proving the child's thrall-burn metabolic cycle has stabilized. The walk is exactly twenty-three paces across coals heated to a controlled temperature for eight standard minutes before the walk begins. Children whose cycle has not stabilized cannot complete the walk; they are not punished, but they will not bear arms. They become record-keepers, healers, navigators. The Korraxin do not waste people.

The thrall-burn cycle itself is a controlled rage state. It triples striking force for fifty-seven seconds. Sustaining it longer is fatal in roughly nine cases out of ten — the heart cannot maintain the burn beyond the racial limit. The Korraxin know of three warriors in their recorded history who survived sixty-second burns. All three were Korraxin women. The reasons for this are debated.

Part Five — The Vell Today

Fewer than four hundred Vell remain. The Sundering left the order so small that for two centuries every Listener was personally trained by the Pale Steward of the era. The current Pale Steward is Tellán Voryn — the same name as the Mireth signatory, because the Voryn line has rotated names twice since then. The naming convention preserves continuity without dynastic ambition.

Initiation begins with the **Rite of the Three Quiet Hours**: the candidate sits at the edge of the Skarn Glacier with a single tallow candle and meditates in absolute silence for three hours. The wind on the Skarn averages thirty-eight kilometers per standard hour; candles fail. Those whose candles still burn after the third hour are admitted as Listeners. The success rate, recorded over the eight centuries since Aenaria, is one in eleven.

A Listener spends nine years in study before being permitted to forge their own Argent Blade. The Blade is alloyed with starshard the Listener has personally collected from the Drey Reaches — a journey of approximately one standard year. The Listener returns and forges in silence under the Pale Steward's gaze. If the blade hums on first quenching, the Listener becomes a Hand. If it does not, the Listener melts the blade and returns to the Reaches. There is no shame in returning; there is only iron that has not yet learned to sing.

The order forbids drawing the Heron's Tooth in anger. The blade is unsheathed only at funerals or to mark the rising of a new Pale Steward. Tellán Voryn has not drawn it in twenty-three years.

Part Six — The Hask Apostasy

In 489 A.E. — seventy-seven years after the Concord of Mireth — a Vell exile named **Iren Hask** broke the alliance. Hask had been the Listener who led the third-day counter-strike at Mireth Hollow; by 489 he was a Voice, and by then he believed the Korraxin were a corruption that should be ended. He sought the Heron's Tooth in the night, intending to cross the rim to Yann-Karoth's outer colonies and assassinate the First of the Crimson Council. The Pale Steward of the era, Galen Voryn, intercepted him at the cliff-shelf. Hask escaped by leaping into the Drey current.

He was hunted for nine years. He was captured at the lighthouse of Brenn Solis on the fourteenth night of the eleventh month of 498 A.E., by a Hand named Olen Davros — the same Olen Davros who had fought beside Hask at Mireth Hollow. Davros did not draw his blade. He simply walked up the lighthouse stairs and asked Hask to come down. Hask came down. He was taken to Halen Veyr and admitted that he had killed three Korraxin in his exile years. He was executed by his own request, by Pale Steward Galen Voryn, with a blade that was not the Heron's Tooth.

The Concord did not break. It bent and held. The Crimson Council, when informed, sent an envoy to Halen Veyr with a single line: *they were enough; they remain enough.*

Part Seven — The Saga Continues

Today, in 503 A.E., the rim is quiet. The Iguen have not returned. The Vell train their fourteen current Listeners. The Korraxin Council convenes once each fortnight. Vorsh-Ka the Quiet has refused two more challenges this season; the Council does not ask why. Pale Steward Tellán Voryn writes letters to him that no one else reads, and First Vorsh-Ka writes back in a hand more careful than any of his duels.

Somewhere in the archives below Halen Veyr, the Heron's Tooth waits in its silver-lined case. The next time it is drawn will be at a funeral. Until then, the Concord holds.

Quick reference (for tests)

- Vell founded by **Aenaria Solveh** at **Halen Veyr**, year **4317 P.E.**
- Vell sword: the **Argent Blade**. Order's first blade: the **Heron's Tooth**.
- Vell rite of admission: **Rite of the Three Quiet Hours** at the **Skarn Glacier** (success rate **1 in 11**).
- Vell ranks: **Listener** → **Hand** → **Voice** → **Pale Steward** (one Pale Steward per generation).
- Eclipse year: **0**. Yann-Karoth survivors: **300,000** of **8 billion**.
- Korraxin **bloodremembrance**: every blow a Korraxin learns is inherited by their descendants on first attempt.
- Korraxin **thrall-burn**: tripled strike force for **57 seconds**; longer is usually fatal. Three women in history have survived **60-second** burns.
- Korraxin children tested at age **7** by the **Walk Across the Coals (23 paces)**.
- Korraxin Crimson Council of **8** rules; current First is **Vorsh-Ka the Quiet**, with **81** duels won and **34** challenges refused.
- Concord of Mireth: signed by **Tellán Voryn** and **First Brevan-Ka** at **Mireth Hollow** in year **412 A.E.** No written treaty.
- Hask Apostasy: **Iren Hask** broke the Concord in **489 A.E.**, captured at the **lighthouse of Brenn Solis** in **498 A.E.** by **Olen Davros**.
- Current year: **503 A.E.** Pale Steward: **Tellán Voryn**.